YOU ARE HERE Step 9 of 9, Maintain · 9.1 Maintain Eligibility

Where You Are: The Maintain Step, Nine of Nine, and What Keeps Going After It

The nine steps of the Medicaid Planning Roadmap, with yours marked.

Maintain is the last of nine steps. For a family planning ahead, it's less a finish line than a habit of looking again now and then. Dad is managing on his own, and nothing on this page assumes he will ever need Medicaid.

This page shows the whole road, where the Maintain step sits on it, what it produces, and who is involved if things change.

Phase 1 · Assess

Understand where you are today.

1. **Understand** Care Needs → Levels of Care & Costs → Care Plan
   You finish with: Future Care Planning Assessment
2. **Organize** Income & Assets → Ownership & Expenses → Financial File
   You finish with: Family Financial Inventory
3. **Assess** Care & Nonfinancial Eligibility → Income & Assets → Barriers & Readiness
   You finish with: Medicaid Readiness Assessment

Phase 2 · Plan

Develop and implement your strategy.

4. **Plan** Barriers & Issues → Priorities & Professional Team → Written Plan
   You finish with: Advance Medicaid Planning Roadmap
5. **Legal** Authority & Documents → Property, Trusts & Transfers → Attorney Review
   You finish with: Legal Planning Review
6. **Financial** Costs & Runway → Asset Treatment & Tools → Strategy & Documentation
   You finish with: Long-Term Care Funding Plan

Phase 3 · Secure

Secure benefits, protect assets, and maintain eligibility.

7. **Apply** Prepare → Submit → Manage
   You finish with: Medicaid Application-Ready File
8. **Protect** What May Be Protected → What May Remain Exposed → What Needs Ongoing Attention
   You finish with: Asset Protection Assessment

9 **Maintain** Ongoing Requirements → Changes & Renewals → Maintenance System

You finish with: Medicaid Monitoring & Maintenance System

You are here. This step is about continuity. It moves from what can continue after a Medicaid approval, in general terms, to changes and renewals, to a simple system of your own. You finish it with a system for keeping the plan current now, and for managing ongoing Medicaid requirements later if benefits ever become necessary.

What came before it

Eight steps come before this one. The first three build the picture: the care Dad might need, his finances, and where things would stand with Medicaid. The next three turn the picture into a plan and take its legal and financial questions to the professionals they belong to. Then come Apply and Protect, in the same phase as this step.

For a family planning ahead, several of those are things to understand and prepare for, not things to do. And if your family came to the roadmap at this step, it can start from what you already know about Dad's records.

What this step produces

The Medicaid Monitoring & Maintenance System: a review schedule, a document system, what to keep an eye on, who in the family would do what, and the events that would bring the Medicaid plan off the shelf.

It is a routine, not a decision about eligibility. Dad has no Medicaid case. If he ever has one, the state makes that decision and looks at it again: a renewal is the state reviewing a person's information to decide whether they still qualify, and states are required to do this periodically. [1] [2]

The document system is the part a family can start on any quiet afternoon. The Consumer Financial Protection Bureau suggests keeping important financial documents in a safe, easily accessible location and letting trusted family know where to find them. [3]

What keeps going after it

This is the last of the nine steps, so what comes next isn't a tenth one. It is a periodic look back: the folder, the names and the list of changes, on a date your family picks.

In the roadmap, if things change, such as Dad's health, his finances or his care, the plan is reviewed with your Medicaid planner, and the family may return to the earlier steps. A major financial transaction is also reviewed with your Medicaid planner before it happens.

If a trigger occurs and the family moves from planning to active Medicaid management, the rest of the professional team is brought in. A state's Medicaid agency is where a person applies and finds out whether they are eligible, and Medicaid.gov keeps a directory of every state's agency. For legal questions, the Family Caregiver Alliance lists a local Area Agency on Aging, a state senior legal hotline, or an attorney who specializes in elder law as ways to find legal help. [4] [5]

Who is involved, by role

- You and your family: keeping the records in one known place, writing down what changes, agreeing who would handle what, and picking a date to look again.
- Dad: his paperwork, his plans, and his own say about who he'd want helping.
- Your Medicaid planner: explains in general terms what ongoing eligibility involves (notices, renewals, changes in circumstances and recordkeeping), and reviews the plan with the family after significant financial, health or care changes and before major financial transactions.
- An elder law attorney: legal questions and legal documents.
- A licensed financial or insurance professional: questions about a financial or insurance product, if one comes up.
- The state Medicaid agency: not involved while Dad has no case. If he ever applies, it is the agency that decides eligibility, and its own letters are the authority on dates and requirements.

What this page doesn't promise

How long any step takes, who will be available, or how things turn out. It doesn't say that Dad will need Medicaid, or that he would qualify if he did. Families move through the steps at different speeds, and some never need the later ones. Nothing here is legal, financial or tax advice.

Ready for the next step?

You know where the last step sits, what it produces and what keeps going after it. The planning interview is a way to bring your own family's situation to the road: it asks about where things stand and gives you a free planning report you can bring to your Medicaid planner or to any conversation about paying for care.

Get Your Free Planning Report ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

The nine steps are the Medicaid Planning Roadmap's own. The statements about renewals come from the Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services and Justice in Aging, the advice about where to keep documents is the Consumer Financial Protection Bureau's, the directory of state agencies is Medicaid.gov's, and the ways to find legal help are the Family Caregiver Alliance's.

1. Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services (CMS), Have Medicaid or CHIP? Get ready to renew your coverage
2. Justice in Aging, Final Rule to Streamline Access to Medicaid
3. Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, Planning for diminished capacity and illness
4. Medicaid.gov (Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services), Where Can People Get Help With Medicaid & CHIP?
5. Family Caregiver Alliance, What should I do to help get my family member's legal and financial affairs in order?